and that the Taliban's links with Pakistan 'will not have an impact on Indo-Afghan ties'.[195]

Similar to the statements issued by Muttawakil and Jalil in 1996 and 1997 respectively, Zaeef noted that India's support to its adversaries counts as interference in Afghanistan's internal affairs. When expectedly asked about the Taliban's support for militants operating in Kashmir, Zaeef was categorical: 'We do not want atrocities to be committed against Kashmiri people ... We condemn any acts of violence by any party. We want to see the Kashmir issue resolved through peaceful dialogue.'[196] There were, of course, no takers of this argument in New Delhi in 2001. As Sood later exhorted 'we could have done business with the likes of Muttawakil and Zaeef.'[197] X states that 'the Taliban never fought against India. They never sent fighters to Kashmir and did not wage a Jihad against us. Whatever few Afghans were found in Kashmir came in an individual capacity and not as Taliban fighters'.[198] Even Dulat wonders why India has had such a closed mindset and why it has not tried in earnest to reach out to the Taliban.[199] Signifying a change in policy over the years, India allowed Zaeef to visit Goa in 2013 for a literary fest called 'Think'.[200] Inviting political ire from opposition parties, Indian officials defended Zaeef's visit on the grounds of opening channels with the Taliban.

If India became more inimical to the Taliban after the IC-814 incident, what was the policy output of the partisans versus conciliatory debate? The outcome was visible not so much in Afghanistan, as much as it was domestically in Kashmir. All three militants released at Kandahar were actively involved in the Kashmiri insurgency, as well as global jihad. Having lost its credibility as a security provider in the wake of IC-814, the BJP government adopted an offensive strategy in Kashmir.[201] On 17 January 2000, a fortnight after the hijack crisis, home minister Advani announced the Union Government's plan to deploy twenty-six companies of the Central Reserve Paramilitary Forces (CRPF) (more than 3,000 personnel) to 'address terrorism' in Kashmir.[202] This was in addition to the six CRPF companies that were already present there. Advani also asked the J&K state-security establishment to 'take a proactive approach against terrorists in the hinterland and establish area domination by day and by night.'[203] Apparently, the BJP's house was divided over Kashmir as well, and not just